The international press, which had been initially slow to react to events in Gdansk, was now overcompensating. Monitoring the situation from Berlin, Honecker rightly worried that ‘one could not completely dismiss the possibility that the Polish germ could spread to East Germany’.2 He looked favourably upon a request from KGB Chairman Yuri Andropov to provide the Stasi’s help in monitoring Poland using a network of informers and spies (an East German journalist was also placed among Lech Wałęsa’s intimate circle).3 Soon after, Polish workers were joined by academics and intellectuals to form a new movement: ‘Solidarity’. In a combative mood, Honecker told television viewers, ‘one thing is clear. Poland is and will remain a socialist country. It belongs inseparably to the world of socialism, and no one can turn back the wheel of history. Together with our friends in the socialist camp, we will see to that.’ He exaggerated when arguing that West Germans along with other Western nations had abetted striking Polish workers.4 ‘Poland is our neighbour,’ he frostily remarked. ‘They want to replace the Soviet shape of socialism with a Polish model. The close alliance and friendship with the Soviet Union forms the sole guarantee for a peaceful future in happiness.’

Shocked as to the extent of the onslaught, Die Welt, asserted Honecker – as an ‘uncompromising governor of Soviet predominance’ – represented Moscow as a satellite as Ulbricht once did. ‘He will do everything he can to prevent the formation of a liberal national movement in Poland, or even the development of national anticommunism which could orientate toward the West.’5 According to BND files, he is even said to have offered to ‘take over the main burden with his troops in the event of a possible invasion of Poland in order to free the Soviet Union from this burden’.6

Suffering anxiety, the harsh rhetoric forced Chancellor Schmidt to again call-off his much-anticipated meeting with Honecker that August. By his own recollection, fearing the Soviet Union and its allies would invade Poland, Schmidt advised Honecker not to participate but received no clear answer. ‘That’s why I had postponed my visit.’ Commenting on the issue, the Frankfurter Rundschau sarcastically noted: ‘They just cannot get together, these two Germans, Schmidt and Honecker. Conditions are not right for the second time this year. First, it was Afghanistan, now it is the Poles who do not allow politics to go according to plan.’7